

Romance Story: A Linguistic Journey [B1]

Oggi, il termine inglese 'romance' indica sia una relazione romantica che un genere letterario. Ma da dove deriva questo termine? Spoiler: ha a che fare con Roma!

In early medieval Europe, in regions formerly conquered by the Romans, ordinary people in their everyday speech spoke a vernacular language that became more and more distant from the Latin used by the Church and in formal writings. Romanised populations started to speak the so-called *romanice*, a Latin adverb meaning 'in the Roman (vernacular) way' or 'in the Romance language,' alluding to the emerging local languages derived from Latin: a language that ordinary people could actually understand, unlike formal Latin. Over the centuries, this spoken language clearly departed from Latin and changed from region to region: these languages would later become Italian, Spanish, French, Portuguese or Romanian, among others.

WESTERN ROMAN EMPIRE

The linguistic phenomenon of the evolution from Latin to Romance vernaculars took place across the entire Western Roman Empire, in all the areas where Latin had taken root. The shift in all Romance-speaking regions began gradually after the 5th century and became more evident between the 8th and 9th centuries. In the Middle Ages, the Latin term 'romanice' was used all over Europe to describe the vernacular languages derived from Latin.

Language

Anglopolis: The Romance in English Oltre al sassone e alla lingua norrena, anche il latino e il francese ebbero un'influenza decisiva sullo sviluppo del vocabolario e soprattutto sull'ortografia dell'inglese moderno. Sarah Presant Collins , Sarah Davison

OLD FRENCH ROMANZ

In medieval France, Old French developed the word 'romanz' to refer to the everyday vernacular language and then, by extension, to popular narrative texts written in that language: usually adventurous [tales](#), stories about [knights](#) and heroes, ideals of [courtly love](#), [chivalry](#) and marvellous or magical events. By the 17th-19th centuries, the word 'romanz' had come to describe narratives opposed to realism, focused instead on idealism, adventure, strong emotions and stories centred on love. The French word eventually became the English 'romance'.

MODERN ENGLISH

In modern English, the term 'romance' refers to love affairs, love stories, and romantic relationships in general. It also defines a literary genre and is still used in reference to medieval [tales](#) of [chivalry](#). In linguistics, however, the expression 'Romance languages' refers to a group of languages that descend from Latin, such as the [aforementioned](#) Italian, Spanish, French, Portuguese, and Romanian.

FALSE FRIENDS

Interestingly, while the adjective 'romantic' has a [broadly](#) similar meaning in English and in most Romance languages, things are a bit different when it comes to the [noun](#) 'romance'. Two notable examples come from Italian and Spanish. In English the word is mostly connected with love stories and romantic relationships, whereas the Italian 'romanzo' means only 'novel', and the Spanish 'romance' refers to a traditional narrative poem in verse, and also to a love affair or a love story.

Glossary

- **formerly** = precedentemente
- **unlike** = a differenza di
- **departed** = distanziarsi
- **had taken root** = mettere radici, attecchire
- **shift** = cambiamento
- **knights** = cavalieri
- **courtly love** = amor cortese
- **chivalry** = cavalleria
- **early medieval** = altomedievale, primi secoli del Medioevo
- **ordinary people** = gente comune
- **tales** = racconti, storie
- **aforementioned** = sopra menzionate
- **broadly** = in generale
- **noun** = nome, sostantivo